Chapter One

The village of Ashford stood at the edge of a wide green valley. Its houses were old, its roads were narrow, and its river ran clear after every storm. Travellers sometimes stopped there by accident, and a few of them decided to stay.

On the first morning of spring, a letter arrived at the post office. It had no stamp, no return address, and no name on the envelope. The postmistress turned it over twice before she called the mayor.

The mayor opened the letter in the square, while half the village watched. Inside was a single sheet of paper with a map drawn in blue ink. The map showed a path that nobody recognized.

The blacksmith said the map was a joke, but he copied it anyway. The schoolteacher said it was a lesson, though she could not explain why. By sunset, three copies were pinned to the door of the inn.

Later, the postmistress remembered the handwriting. It looked like her own. She searched her desk for a pen and found the drawer empty. For a long moment, she said nothing to anyone.

Chapter Two

By noon, the path had become the only subject of conversation. Some said it led to the old mill; others said it led nowhere at all. The children were forbidden to follow it, which naturally made them curious.

The exam-
ple was difficult, but the teacher had prepared them well. Every student remembered the lesson about maps and misleading signs. They promised to stay on the road and to be home before dark.

That evening, the mayor walked to the edge of the village alone. He carried a lantern, the letter, and a compass that had belonged to his father. The path began between two apple trees, exactly where the map said it would.

He followed it until the lantern light reached a low stone wall. Beyond the wall, the valley opened into a field of pale grass. The compass needle turned once and then became still.